



next set of players.

Their replacements, including the five who made their Test debuts against England earlier this year — Sarfaraz Khan, Rajat Patidar, Akash Deep, Jurel and Devdutt Padikkal — have been slotted across the four teams.

There is also space for Riyan Parag, Harshit Rana and Tilak Varma, who have made a name largely through their T20 exploits.

With Ashwin, 37, and Ravindra Jadeja, 35, approaching the final stages of their careers, R. Sai Kishore, Saransh Jain, Tanush Kotian, and Manav Suthar — who have tirelessly honed their skills in the domestic circuit — will be eager to solidify their candidacy when an

opening arises in the upper echelons.

Testing bench strength

India's home Test series against Bangladesh starts on September 19, while the Duleep Trophy is slated to run from September 5 to 22. Due to the dates coinciding, the first-team mainstays, including Shubman, Kuldeep Yadav and Yashasvi Jaiswal are likely to depart after the first game. However, the selectors could also find it prudent to protect the mainstays, or even let them carry on with the Duleep Trophy.

India is fairly well placed to advance to a third consecutive World Test Championship final, enabling the selectors to back young guns

At the helm: Shubman Gill will lead Team A that has the likes of Riyan Parag, K. L. Rahul, Shivam Dube and Kuldeep Yadav. **K. R. DEEPAK**

without hesitation.

The urge to use Bumrah sparingly will leave the field open to quicks Arshdeep Singh and Tushar Deshpande to earn a Test cap.

But beyond opening up slots for youngsters, India's crammed Test schedule allows First-Class cricket a long-overdue return to vogue.

With the team management emphasising the importance of maintaining a strong talent pipeline, it seems likely that this trend will continue.